The Say It Back System

A three-step habit, and the AI prompts that run it, so nothing you hear or decide gets lost between your head and the work.

Most people are great at nodding. Be great at confirming.

Do not assume you understood.

If listening and remembering is not how your brain works best, stop relying on it. Build a small system that proves the message landed.

1 **Do not assume you understand.** A nod is not understanding. Treat every instruction, brief or decision as unconfirmed until you have said it back.

2 **Say it back.** In your own words, out loud or in writing, in one or two sentences.

3 **Get it confirmed.** The other side says yes, or corrects you. Either result is a win.

THE LINE THAT WORKS

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Here's what I heard.
Here's what I'm doing.
Correct me if I'm wrong.
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It is a communication advantage, not a workaround.

Let AI be the one who says it back.

You do not need another person for this. Talk the thing out, and let AI return it as a plan you can check in ten seconds.

RAMBLE TO PLAN

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I am going to ramble about something I need to do. Do not interrupt.
When I say "done", reply in this exact shape:
HERE'S WHAT I HEARD: two sentences.
HERE'S WHAT I'M DOING: a numbered list of the next steps, five at
most, each one action.
CORRECT ME IF I'M WRONG: the two things you were least sure about, as
questions.
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Use voice dictation. Mess is fine. The questions at the end are the useful part: they show you exactly where your own thinking was fuzzy.

You direct. It does the operating.

Three places it pays for itself.

CALLS

Within ten minutes of a call, send: "Here's what I heard, here's what I'm doing, correct me if I'm wrong." Three lines. Nobody can say later it was unclear.

BRIEFS

Before you hand work to a freelancer, an assistant or an AI, ask them to say the brief back in their words first. Fix it before they start, not after.

DECISIONS

When you decide something fast, say it back to yourself in writing: what, by when, what you are not doing. Future you will not remember the reasoning.

TURN MY NOTES INTO THE FOLLOW-UP

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Here are my rough notes from a call: [paste]. Write the follow-up
message in three parts: Here's what I heard. Here's what I'm doing.
Correct me if I'm wrong. Keep it under 90 words and write it the way
I speak: warm, direct, no jargon.
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Four more, ready to use.

INSTRUCTION CHECK

Here is an instruction I was given: [paste]. Say it back to me in plain words, list what is unclear, and write the one question I should ask to remove the biggest doubt.

BRIEF CHECK

Here is the brief I am about to send: [paste]. Read it as the person receiving it. Say it back to me in three sentences, then tell me what they are most likely to get wrong.

END OF DAY

Here is a ramble about what I decided and agreed today: [paste]. Give me a list of commitments with who, what and when, and flag anything I said yes to that I have no time to do.

WEEKLY NOD CHECK

Here are my commitments from this week: [paste]. Which ones did I agree to without really confirming the details? Give me one clarifying message for each.

Three things, in order.

1 **Today:** after your next conversation, send the three-line Here's what I heard message. Just one.

2 **This week:** use Ramble to plan once a day, before your first piece of work. Two minutes.

3 **Next week:** ask everyone who briefs you, and everyone you brief, to say it back. Make it how you work.

Systems beat discipline. You do not need to become someone who remembers everything. You need a small habit that catches what slips.

A working routine to adapt. Change the words until they sound like you.

Direct the work. Let the system carry it.